

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Waqas Khan

Address: 7 Wyndham Close Sutton Sutton SM2 6JF

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am writing to express my strong support for the above planning application for the proposed community centre development. I believe this facility will deliver significant community benefits and aligns with Sutton Council's planning objectives for social and community infrastructure.

1. Meets Identified Local Need for Community and Family Space

The proposed community centre will provide important social infrastructure for families in the local area. There is currently a lack of accessible indoor space where children and young people can participate in everyday activities, sports, and family events in a safe and inclusive environment. The centre would serve as a destination for children's clubs, family gatherings, educational programmes, and intergenerational activities, offering a consistent community hub beyond temporary or ad hoc spaces.

By providing space for youth activities, the centre will help to strengthen community cohesion, reduce social isolation, and support positive development for children and families - outcomes which are central aims of sustainable neighbourhood planning.

2. Accessible by Walking and Reduces Traffic Impact

One of the key planning principles in Sutton's adopted Local Plan is that social and community infrastructure should be accessible by a range of transport modes, in particular by walking.

The proposed centre is within easy walking distance for residents in the surrounding neighbourhood. Many families, including mine, can comfortably attend by foot, which will help reduce local car use and align with sustainable transport objectives. The accessibility of the location will encourage consistent use by children after school, families attending community events, and attendees of daily and weekly programmes.

3. Supports Existing Religious and Community Activities

Our family, like many others in the area, already attends Friday prayers and activities organised by Basma in the nearby church hall. The proposed community centre will expand our ability to gather for prayers, family activities, and cultural events in a dedicated space that can better support growing attendance and additional programmes.

Having a centre with appropriate facilities will better accommodate prayer spaces, meeting rooms, and multipurpose halls where faithbased, cultural, and family activities can run safely and inclusively.

4. Proven Community Value and Reduced Impact Compared to Previous Use

The former use of the site as an ambulance centre operated 24 hours per day, which understandably generated noise and vehicle movements around the clock. The proposed community centre will operate at far reduced hours, focused on planned activities, and will generate significantly less noise and disruption for neighbours. This change improves residential amenity while providing a daytime and early evening resource for families, children, and local groups.

This aligns with the National Planning Policy Framework and local planning objectives to ensure that development "would not have any adverse environmental effects".

5. Enhances Indoor Sports and Active Living Opportunities

The centre will also include indoor sports and activity spaces. Sutton Council's infrastructure planning recognises the importance of indoor sports, leisure, and community facilities as part of a high quality of life for residents.

Providing such facilities will:

Promote healthy lifestyles, especially for children and young people.

Offer structured exercise classes and sports clubs.

Support local wellbeing targets and encourage lifelong participation in physical activity.

This is of even greater importance where existing provision is limited or oversubscribed.

6. No Loss of Essential Services, Only a Gain in Community Benefit

The proposal does not remove an existing valued community use. On the contrary, it replaces underutilised infrastructure with a resource that meets current and anticipated local needs for social, cultural, and familyfocused facilities. This is entirely consistent with planning policy which supports new social and community infrastructure where it is accessible and serves a demonstrable need.

Conclusion

For the reasons outlined above, I strongly support the planning application for the community centre at this site. The proposals will deliver sustainable, accessible, and multipurpose facilities that benefit children, families, faith groups, and the wider community. I urge the Council to grant planning permission for this application.

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Thank you for considering this support.